Stay, React, or Conform? Examining Social Influence Effects on Aesthetic Judgments

Abstract

In this research note, we address the question, foundational to sociological studies of taste, of the extent to which others' aesthetic judgments influence the transient evaluation of cultural works, and the extent to which this influence depends on the social distance between self and other. Drawing on classic and recent cultural theory, we hypothesize that high (low) status respondents (as indexed by educational attainment) will be more likely to change their judgment of a cultural object in a negative direction when exposed to information about the negative aggregate judgment of other persons of high (low) status in comparison to when those judgments come from others of low (high) status. We use a quasi-experimental design to manipulate both exposure to others' evaluations and the status characteristics of those others.

1 Introduction

1.1 Theoretical Background

Taste expressions and consumption have long been shown to be a function of individuals' desire to differentiate themselves from others (Simmel, 1957; DiMaggio, 1987). Bourdieu (1984) suggests that taste differences evoke a visceral reaction, and it is through the rejection of others' aesthetic tastes that individuals engage in the symbolic boundary work that separates them. Thus, the expression of distastes serves to communicate social distance from certain social groups (Bryson, 1996; Lamont and Molnár, 2002). In contexts where individuals discover a similarity in taste with members of a meaningful outgroup, they frequently engage in "taste abandonment" to maintain social boundaries (Berger and Heath, 2008), while contexts in which individuals find a similarity of tastes with members of their ingroup can foster community and solidarity (**??**). Nevertheless, despite the lively existing discussion on the relationship between cultural familiarity and network connections (Erickson, 1996; Lizardo, 2006), relatively little is known about the dynamic mechanisms underlying symbolic boundary work in real time.

In the research reported in this paper, we ask: How does access to the evaluations of others influence our own aesthetic evaluations of cultural objects? The simplest answer to this question sees the production of aesthetic judgments as a special case of judgment under uncertainty. This means that information about other people's judgments becomes a key cog in a *generalized influence mechanism*. The basic idea behind generalized influence is simple: in any context where there is uncertainty about how to evaluate a cultural object, access to information about how others have evaluated it provides a heuristic for resolving that uncertainty (Strang and Macy, 2001). As such, according to this view, individuals will tend to adjust their own evaluations in a direction consistent with the valence of other people's evaluations. For instance, discovering that a cultural object is broadly endorsed by others (regardless of those others' characteristics) often increases its appeal (Positive Generalized Alignment), while discovering it is disliked decreases its appeal (Negative Generalized Alignment), as has been shown in previous work (Salganik et al., 2006).

However, cultural influence is rarely so monolithic; the status of the "others" matters. Exposure to the preferences of a high-status group might induce *conformity* (alignment), whereas exposure to a low-status or out-group might induce *reactance* (distancing). This approach is consistent with traditional models in the sociology of culture and consumption, which use a balance-like logic (Heider, 1946) to predict how information about other people's choices (either explicit or implied) affects judgments of taste. These models suggest that access to positive evaluations from others will increase subjective evaluations of worth when those others are positively regarded, but not when they are negatively regarded. In the same way, access to other people's negative evaluations will lead to a decrease in subjective evaluations of worth when those others are positively regarded (Lizardo and Skiles, 2016). Here influence operates as either conformity or "goodwill" (Bourdieu, 1984) when the presumed others are high-status, or as rejection or "symbolic boundary drawing" when others are low-status (Bryson, 1996).

A "Bourdieusian" (Bourdieu, 1984) version of this model adds the complicating factor of the focal person's own position in the social space, suggesting that goodwill and conformity to the opinions of presumed high-status others should be more prevalent among lower status respondents, while resistance and distancing from the judgments of presumed low-status others should be more prevalent among higher status persons (Lizardo and Skiles, 2016).

While the Bourdieusian symbolic power model predicts goodwill (conformity on the part of lower-status persons to the judgments of high-status others) and equally possible pattern of results is that of generalized reactance, or the symbolic "war of all against all" where low-status others distance their judgments against those perceived to be higher status, while higher status people do the same against those of perceived lower status Tampubolon (2008).

In what follows, we put these considerations to the test by specifically examining how the respondent's objective and subjective class status interact with the fictional group's class status to produce theoretically distinct behaviors: *staying* (resisting influence), conforming (influence as a form of alignment), or reacting (influence as a form of distancing).

1.2 Hypotheses

Baseline Condition (Mere Exposure Effect):
Overall, we expect that mere exposure to the same cultural object across repeated trials results in an average improvement in evaluation, even in the absence of information about how other people evaluate the object (Reber et al., 1998). Access to information about other people's evaluations can block or facilitate the mere exposure effect.

Generalized Influence in the Evaluation Only Condition:

- **Positive Evaluations:** Positive evaluations (liking) from generalized others should have an overall positive influence on the respondent's second evaluation, facilitating the baseline drift.

- **Negative Evaluations:** Negative evaluations (disliking) from generalized others should have an overall negative influence on the respondent's second evaluation, blocking the mere exposure effect.

When examining status plus evaluation conditions involving cross-status reactance and symbolic power, we advance three primary hypotheses:

- **Hypothesis 1 (same-status alignment)** posits that individuals will adjust their judgments to align with the aggregate judgment of their status peers. That is, both high- and low-status respondents will change their judgments in a positive direction when exposed to the positive judgments of others sharing their status, and in a negative direction when exposed to their negative judgments.

- **Hypothesis 2 (symbolic power and upward alignment)** predicts that low-status respondents will align their judgments with the aggregate judgments of high-status others, adopting their positive evaluations and conforming to their negative evaluations.

- **Hypothesis 3 (cross-status reactance)** suggests that individuals will distance themselves from the aggregate judgments of out-group members, particularly low-status others. Thus, respondents will shift their judgments negatively when exposed to the positive judgment of an out-group, and positively when exposed to their negative judgment.

2 Data and Methods

2.1 Experimental Design and Data

We utilize data from the SSI-2012 survey. The core of the study is a within-subject experimental design where respondents rate an artwork on a 7-point scale, are exposed to a treatment condition, and then rate the artwork again. The final analytical sample consists of 2,253 respondents with complete initial and post-treatment evaluations. Respondents were randomly assigned to one of nine experimental and control conditions. Sample sizes are well-balanced across the baseline and taste-only control conditions ($N \approx 175$ per condition) as well as across the specific class-status treatment conditions ($N \approx 290$ per condition, noting that the '+Status' treatments each consist of two sub-conditions combined, yielding $N \approx 575$ for the collapsed high-status conditions).

All respondents viewed an image of the same painting: *Nocturne: Battersea Bridge*, by James McNeill Whistler (1872). Figure 1 displays the artwork used as the experimental stimulus. This specific painting was selected based on feedback gathered from an online pilot study conducted in June 2011, which tested images of eight paintings on a convenience sample of respondents. The Whistler painting was chosen for the main experiment because it elicited the highest variation in baseline opinions across all measured demographic characteristics, preventing floor or ceiling effects.

Figure 1: Experimental Stimulus: *Nocturne: Battersea Bridge*, by James McNeill Whistler (1872)

The experimental protocol proceeded as follows: Respondents first gave their initial impression of the painting on a 1–7 scale ranging from "like it very much" to "dislike it very much." This expression serves as a baseline measure of taste, uninfluenced by external information. Next, respondents in the treatment groups were told that the group of people most likely to either like or dislike the painting possessed specific education and occupation characteristics.

The treatment conditions vary along three dimensions regarding this fictional alter group. The first dimension is taste evaluation, denoting whether the alter group liked or disliked the artwork. The second dimension is the status of the alter, contrasting high-status individuals (characterized by a college education and middle-class standing) with low-status individuals (working class and lacking a college degree). The final dimension is the control or no-status condition, which includes scenarios where only the alter's taste is known without providing any class information, alongside a pure baseline control group.

2.2 Variables

Our analysis utilizes several key variables from the SSI-2012 dataset.

Dependent Variables: The baseline measure of taste was captured by asking respondents to evaluate the painting on a 1–7 ordinal scale. We reversed the original coding so that higher values indicate greater affinity (1 = "I dislike it very much", 4 = "I neither like it nor dislike it", 7 = "I like it very much"). The primary dependent variable is the shift in this aesthetic evaluation across the two trials. We analyze this outcome in two primary ways: as a continuous change score, and as a nominal behavioral outcome categorized as *staying* (no change in evaluation), *conforming* (moving toward the alter group's evaluation), or *reacting* (moving away from the alter group's evaluation).

Independent Variables: The primary independent variables consist of the experimental condition factors indicating the alter group's status and evaluation. These include combinations of Alter Taste (Like/Dislike) and Alter Status (+Status: Middle-class/College-educated vs. -Status: Working-class/No College), alongside baseline control conditions and conditions providing only taste information without class status.

Moderating Status Variables: We include respondent status consistency as a moderating variable, captured by crossing an objective measure of educational attainment with a subjective measure of class identification. Subjective class is a binary indicator created by collapsing a 4-point self-identification scale (lower class and working class = Working Class; middle class and upper class = Middle Class). Objective education is a binary indicator of whether the respondent holds a college degree (Bachelor's, Master's, or Doctoral/Professional degree vs. no college degree). Crossing these yields four status groups: Working/No College, Working/College, Middle/No College, and Middle/College.

Covariates for IPW Balancing: Because respondents are not randomly assigned to their social class or educational attainment, these groups differ systematically on basic demographics. To isolate the true moderating effect of social class and education, we utilize Inverse Probability Weighting (IPW) to balance four covariates across the status groups: *age* (a 14-category ordinal variable treated as continuous, ranging from "18–19" to "80+"), *gender* (binary: 1 = women, 0 = men), *race/ethnicity* (a 6-category variable: Asian, Black, Hispanic, White, ¿1 race, and other), and *parents' education* (binary: 1 = parent has college degree, 0 = no parent college degree, capturing intergenerational educational capital).

2.3 Analytic Strategy

Our data consists of repeated measures (before and after providing access to others' evaluations) of the respondent's aesthetic evaluation of a cultural object. Because repeated measures are correlated within subjects (but independent across subjects), we rely on random-effects models as a natural framework to simultaneously model within and between subjects variance. We use hierarchically nested versions of the mixed-effects model via maximum likelihood and use likelihood ratio tests to select the best fit.

To overcome the limitations of standard linear regression and fully test our hypotheses regarding alignment versus distancing, we additionally employ two advanced modeling techniques. First, we utilize multinomial logistic regression. While linear mixed models estimate the average magnitude and direction of shifts, they obscure the underlying distribution of behaviors. For example, an average shift of zero could mean complete rigidity, or it could mean polarized halves of conformity and reactance canceling each other out. To address this, we use a multinomial logistic regression to explicitly model the discrete probabilities of three theoretically distinct behaviors: maintaining one's evaluation (staying), moving toward the group (conforming), or moving away from the group (reacting). Second, we employ inverse probability weighting (IPW) on all models to balance demographic covariates—including age, gender, race, and parental education—across the observational status groups. This ensures that the estimated moderating effects of class are not confounded by other demographic differences.

All results reported below utilize these IPW weights to ensure unbiased estimates of the status interactions.

3 Results

3.1 Covariate Balance

Before evaluating the hypotheses, we assessed the covariate balance across the observational status groups. Because respondents are not randomly assigned to their social class or educational attainment, these groups differ systematically on demographics (age, gender, race, parent's education). We applied Propensity Score Weighting (IPW) to balance these covariates. As shown in Figure 2, weighting effectively eliminated demographic imbalances across the status categories. All subsequent analyses utilize these weights to isolate the true moderating effect of social class and education.

3.2 Evaluating the Mere Exposure Effect

The baseline condition allows us to observe the counterfactual drift in aesthetic evaluations over repeated trials without external influence. Our analysis of the trial effects (Figure 3) provides mixed support for a universal mere exposure effect. While college-educated respondents (both Working and Middle class) exhibit a significant positive drift in evaluations across trials, respondents without a college degree exhibit no significant change. Thus, the mere exposure effect is not uniform but contingent on educational capital.

3.3 Evaluating Generalized Influence

In the "No Status" conditions, we hypothesized that positive evaluations from generalized others would facilitate the baseline drift, while negative evaluations would block it. The

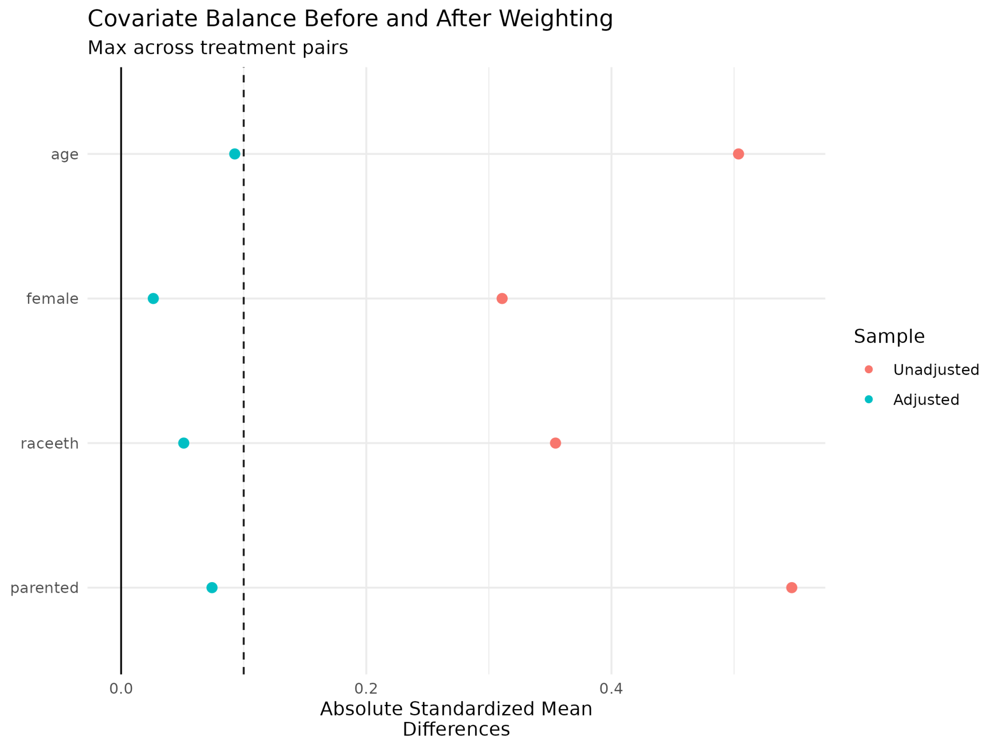

Figure 2: Covariate Balance Before and After Weighting

results partially support this: exposure to positive evaluations produces significant positive shifts, particularly for Middle Class individuals without a college degree. Conversely, exposure to generalized negative evaluations largely suppresses the positive baseline drift across all groups, resulting in null trial effects, exactly as predicted.

3.4 Evaluating Status-Based Influence (Hypotheses 1–3)

When introducing the class status of the fictional alter group, we observe complex dynamics that challenge linear theories of social influence.

Hypothesis 1 (Same-status alignment) predicted that respondents would align their judgments with the positive and negative judgments of their own status peers. This finds *mixed support*. High-status respondents (Middle Class, College) show a significant positive shift when exposed to the "Like / High Status" condition, but no significant negative shift when exposed to the "Dislike / High Status" condition. In contrast, Low-status respondents (Working Class, No College) do not align in the "Like / Low Status" condition, and strikingly, they show a significant *positive* shift (distancing) when exposed to the "Dislike / Low Status" condition. Thus, low-status individuals actively react against the negative tastes of their own peers.

Hypothesis 2 (Symbolic power/upward alignment) predicted that Low-status respondents would align with High-status judgments. We find *partial support*. Low-status respondents do exhibit a significant positive shift in the "Like / High Status" condition. However, they exhibit null shifts in the "Dislike / High Status" condition, rather than con-

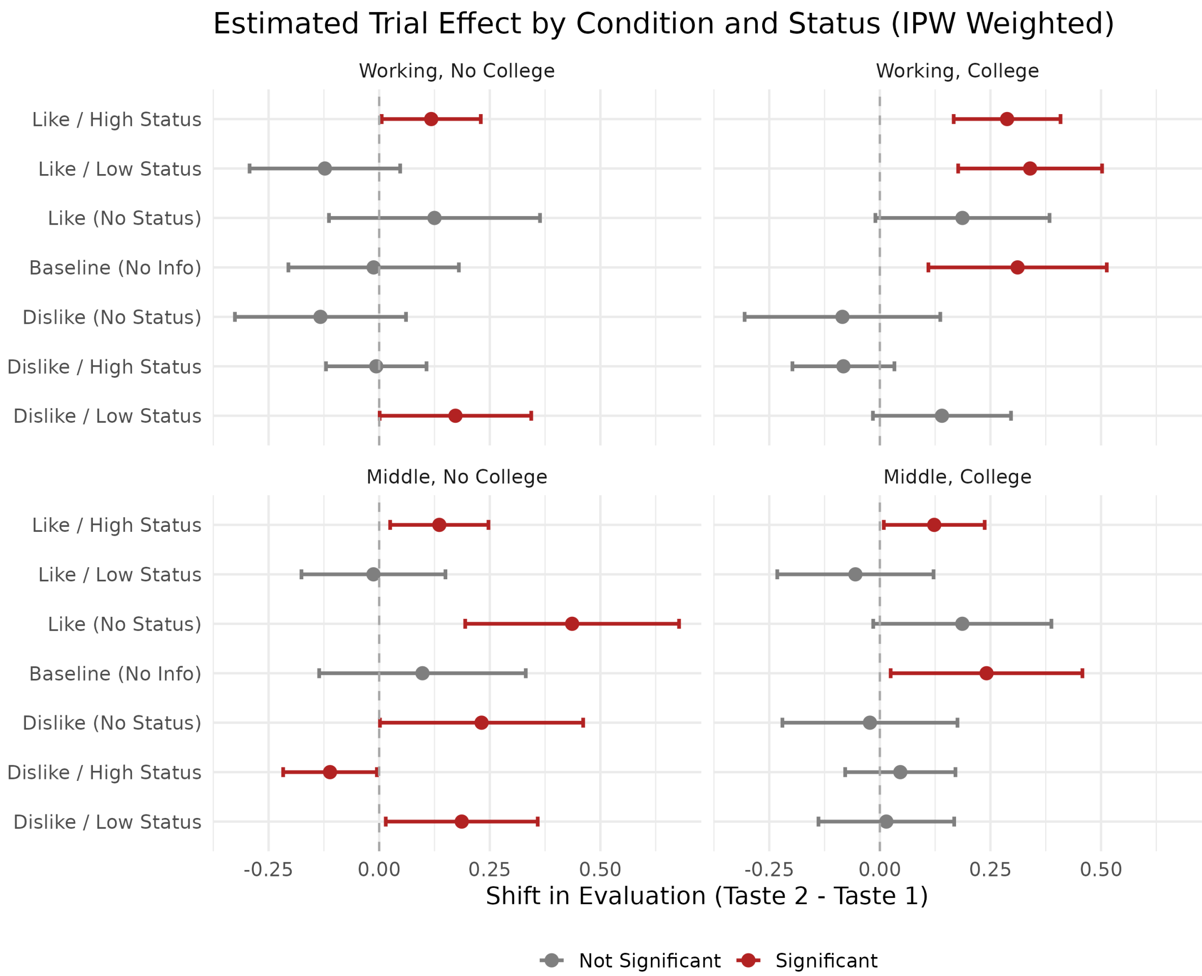

Figure 3: Estimated Trial Effect by Condition and Status. Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.

formity.

Hypothesis 3 (Cross-status reactance) predicted distancing when exposed to out-group judgments. This is *not supported*. High-status respondents do not significantly distance (shift negatively) from the "Like / Low Status" condition, nor do they distance (shift positively) from the "Dislike / Low Status" condition. The strongest distancing behavior in the data actually occurs within-group (Low-status respondents reacting against the "Dislike / Low Status" condition), suggesting that reactance is driven more by avoiding low-status stigma than by strict cross-status boundaries.

3.5 Disaggregating Types of Change in Judgments of Taste: Conformity vs. Reactance

While the continuous change score models provide the average magnitude and direction of taste shifts, they obscure the underlying categorical behaviors. For instance, an average linear shift of zero could indicate that all respondents maintained their original evaluation, or it could indicate that half the respondents strongly conformed while the other half strongly reacted, canceling each other out in the aggregate. Furthermore, analyzing average shifts does not allow us to isolate the baseline propensity to simply maintain one's taste (aesthetic rigidity) versus changing it.

To capture these distinct behaviors, we map the continuous shifts onto three discrete categories—Stay, Conform, and React—and fit a Multinomial Logistic Regression model.

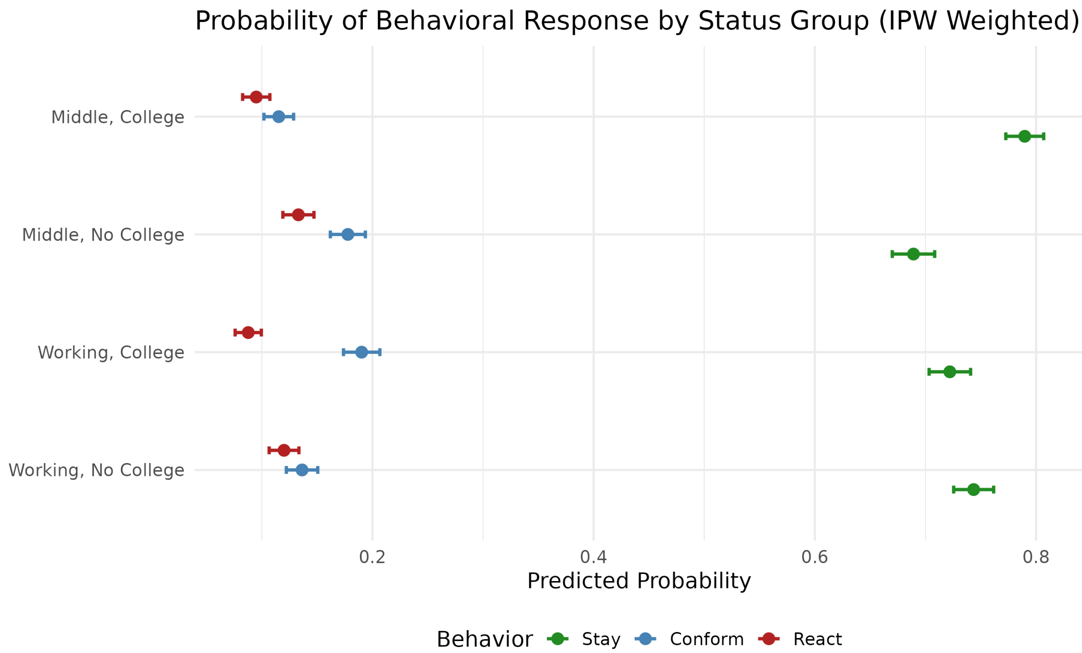

Figure 4: Probability of Behavioral Response by Status Group

This behavioral disaggregation clarifies why the linear hypotheses (H1–H3) yielded mixed results. For instance, we see that status consistent individuals, and particularly high-status consistent individuals have the highest propensity to *stay* with their initial judgment of taste (Middle Class/College: 79.0%; Working Class/No College: 74.4%), a classic behavioral indicator of high status (**?**). Thus, these individuals are the most "assured" in their aesthetic judgment and least prone to influence.

When it comes to conformity, however, we can see that *status inconsistency* (**?**), or an individual's location in a "contradictory" area of the social space (Bourdieu, 1984), plays an important role, fundamentally altering the propensity to conform regardless of the status of the specific alter involved. As Figure 4 reveals, self-identified Middle Class individuals without a college degree (17.8%) and Working Class individuals with a College Degree (19.0%) are highly prone to *conformity*. Meanwhile, when it comes to *reactance* we see mainly an education effect, with non-college educated individuals (regardless of subjective class identification) being more likely to react (Middle Class/No College: 13.3%; Working Class/No College: 12.0%), compared to college-educated individuals (Middle Class/College: 9.5%; Working Class/College: 8.8%).

4 Discussion and Conclusion

Our analysis shows that aesthetic judgments are indeed malleable and subject to influence, but not uniformly so. As a way of discussion, we return to the theoretical ideas we began with, to highlight how our findings advance the conversation, while opening up new questions.

First, our results offer some qualifications to studies who rely on generalized influence mechanisms as a main explanatory factor. While previous research suggests that information about others' choices acts as a heuristic to resolve uncertainty (Strang and Macy, 2001; Salganik et al., 2006), we find that valence matters. Positive generalized evaluations successfully facilitated positive taste shifts (Positive Generalized Alignment). However, generalized negative evaluations did not cause outright negative shifts; instead, they merely suppressed the baseline mere exposure effect (the natural tendency for tastes to drift upward upon reevaluation). This suggests that cultural "likes" are more contagious than cultural "dislikes" when there is not much information as to who is doing the liking or disliking.

Second, the findings challenge strict Bourdieusian models of symbolic power and balance-like logic (Heider, 1946; Bourdieu, 1984). We found only partial support for upward alignment (where lower-status actors conform to higher-status tastes). While low-status individuals showed "goodwill" by aligning with high-status positive evaluations, they completely ignored high-status negative evaluations. Once again, here we see a valence-asymmetry, with goodwill being more likely to be driven by positive evaluations than negative evaluations.

Third, our analysis also serves to qualify theories of symbolic boundary work (Bryson, 1996; Berger and Heath, 2008; Tampubolon, 2008; Lizardo and Skiles, 2016). Some of these theories predict cross-status reactance, where high-status individuals distance themselves from low-status tastes. However, we found no significant evidence of high-status respondents actively distancing from low-status out-groups. Instead, the most striking reactance occurred *within* the low-status group: working-class individuals distanced their tastes away from the negative evaluations of working-class peers. This implies that in this case, the revision of the initial judgment of taste is driven less by cross-class antagonism and more by an aversion to low-status stigma.

Finally, our analysis of the three Simmelian forms that over time taste judgments could take, namely, staying with the old judgment (assurance), conforming to the judgment of others or reacting against such judgment revealed some intriguing findings. We find that status inconsistency is an important driver of aesthetic fluidity, with inconsistent individuals being more likely to conform to the taste of others. Meanwhile, non-college educated are more likely to react by revising their judgments of taste away from that of others.

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A Sensitivity Analysis: Isolating Class Feedback

To ensure that the results in the main text are driven by the *class status* of the fictional alter groups, we ran a sensitivity analysis dropping the "No Status" conditions.

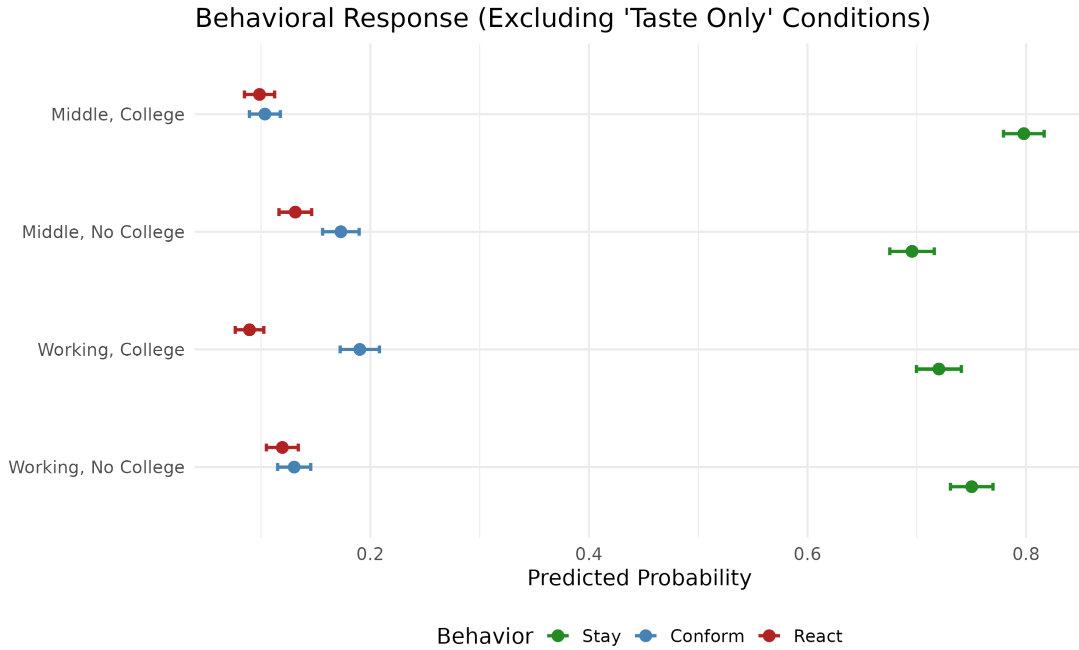

Figure 5: Behavioral Response (Excluding 'No Status' Conditions)

As shown in Figure 5, the probability distributions of conformity versus reactance remain highly consistent with the main findings. This confirms that the presence of class-based status information uniquely structures the evaluation shifts of respondents, rather than simply the presence of any group evaluation.

B Robustness Check: Alternative Definition of Social Class

In the main analysis, the subjective class measure was constructed as a binary indicator by collapsing a 4-point scale: respondents who selected "lower class" or "working class" were coded as Working Class, and those who selected "middle class" or "upper class" were coded as Middle Class. To ensure that the results are not driven by the inclusion of the extremes (lower and upper class), we conducted a robustness check restricting the sample strictly to respondents who explicitly selected "working class" or "middle class."

We re-estimated both the linear mixed models evaluating trial effects (the continuous change score analysis) and the multinomial logistic regression (evaluating the discrete probabilities of staying, conforming, or reacting) on this restricted sample. The models were again balanced using Inverse Probability Weighting (IPW) on age, gender, race/ethnicity, and parents' education.

The results from this alternative specification are virtually identical to those in the main text. For the continuous change scores, the direction and significance of all condition-specific shifts remain unchanged. For the behavioral analysis, the probability distributions are remarkably consistent: status-consistent groups maintain the highest propensity to *stay* (Middle Class/College: 78.2%; Working Class/No College: 74.7%), status-inconsistent groups maintain the highest propensity to *conform* (Middle Class/No College: 17.9%; Working Class/College: 16.9%), and those without a college degree remain the most likely to *react* (Middle Class/No College: 13.3%; Working Class/No College: 12.1%). This confirms that the observed social class dynamics are robust and not artifacts of how the extreme ends of the class distribution were collapsed.